Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 23 · DAYS 820-836

The Better Covenant: Hebrews

Hebrews 1-13

Jesus is the fulfillment of every type, shadow, and promise in the Old Testament.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses... Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace."

HEBREWS 4:15-16

Psalms 95, 40, 110, and 22, which Hebrews quotes.

UNIT 23

In this unit

WEEK 118

820	Hebrews 1:1-2:18	*Reading*
821	Hebrews 3:1-4:13	*Reading*
822	Hebrews 4:14-6:20	*Reading*
823	Psalm 95	*Psalm*
824	Psalm 40:1-10	*Psalm*
825	Psalm 110	*Psalm*
826	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 119

827	Hebrews 7:1-28	*Reading*
828	Hebrews 8:1-9:28	*Reading*
829	Hebrews 10:1-39	*Reading*
830	Acts 2:42-47; Hebrews 10:24-25	*Doctrine*
831	Hebrews 11:1-40	*Reading*
832	Hebrews 12:1-29	*Reading*
833	Sabbath Rest	*Sabbath*

WEEK 120

834	Hebrews 13:1-25	*Reading*
835	Psalm 22	*Psalm*
836	Review and Reflection	*Review*

DAY 820 · WEEK 118

Hebrews 1:1-2:18

The Son above angels; the founder of salvation

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 1:1-2:18 in one sitting if you can. Hebrews does not begin like a letter. It begins like a sermon, and it starts by announcing who Jesus is. As you read, count the ways the author describes the Son and notice how often he quotes the Old Testament to prove it. Don't worry about catching every reference. Let the weight of the opening sentence settle on you.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

We are about to begin a book unlike any other in the New Testament. Hebrews has no greeting, no named author, and no named recipients. It opens with a single, majestic sentence in Greek and moves quickly into a sustained argument. The original readers were Jewish Christians who were under pressure. They were tempted to retreat from Christ and return to the safer, more familiar patterns of Moses and the temple. The author's response is not to scold them first but to show them Jesus. Everything depends on seeing that the Son is better than anything they might be tempted to go back to. For us, the book is a gift because it explains, from the inside, how the entire Old Testament points to Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. God spoke "long ago" by the prophets in many portions and ways, but "in these last days" by his Son (1:1-2).
2. The Son is heir of all things and the agent through whom the world was made (1:2).
3. He is "the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature," and he upholds the universe by his word (1:3).

4. After making purification for sins, he “sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high” (1:3).
5. Hebrews 1:5-13 strings together seven Old Testament quotations to show that the Son is superior to angels.
6. Hebrews 1:8 applies the word “God” to the Son: “Your throne, O God, is forever and ever.”
7. Hebrews 2:1-4 is the first of several warnings: “we must pay much closer attention to what we have heard.”
8. Hebrews 2:14-18 explains that the Son shared in flesh and blood so that through death he might destroy the devil and free those who feared death.

STEP 4

Interpretation

The first four verses of Hebrews are one of the most compressed statements of Christology in the Bible. The author begins with a contrast that organizes the whole book: God spoke before, and God has now spoken in a final way. The prophets were real messengers with real messages, delivered in pieces and fragments. But the Son is not another fragment. He is the full and final word. Everything the prophets pointed toward has now arrived in a person.

Then come the seven descriptions of the Son. He is heir, which means everything belongs to him. He is the agent of creation, which echoes John 1 and Colossians 1. He is the radiance of God’s glory, like light that streams from the sun and shares its nature. He is the exact imprint of God’s being, like the impression stamped by a seal. He sustains all things by his powerful word. He made purification for sins. And he sat down. That last detail matters: a priest in the old covenant never sat, because the work was never finished. Christ sat because his work was done.

Having established who the Son is, the author turns to prove it from Scripture, and he starts with angels. This may seem odd to us, but in Jewish thought angels were awesome mediators of God’s law (see Acts 7:53 and Galatians 3:19). To say the Son is greater than angels is to say he is greater than the mediation that came through them. The seven quotations in chapter 1 are drawn from the Psalms and the prophets, and they are all applied to Jesus. The most striking is verse 8, where the Father himself says to the Son, “Your throne, O God, is forever and ever.” The Father addresses the Son as God.

Chapter 2 opens with a warning that the author will repeat in different forms. If the message delivered through angels was binding and every transgression received a just penalty, how can we escape if we neglect so great a salvation? Notice the verb. The danger is not primarily active rebellion but drifting. The slow, quiet neglect of Christ is how many people leave him.

The rest of chapter 2 turns from the Son's glory to his humiliation, and it is a beautiful turn. How can the one who is greater than angels be made "for a little while lower than the angels"? Because he came to taste death for everyone. The one who made the world entered it, took on flesh and blood, and died. Verses 14-15 tell us why: to destroy the one who has the power of death, the devil, and to deliver those who all their lives were enslaved by fear. Fear of death is a master, and Christ has broken its power.

Verse 17 introduces a theme that will dominate the book: he had to be made like his brothers in every respect, so that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest. The Son who is God became truly human so he could represent us before God. He is not simply above us. He is with us, and he is for us.

STEP 5

Connection

The seven descriptions in 1:1-4 echo Proverbs 8 and Wisdom language, Genesis 1 (creation by word), and Psalm 110:1 (the session at God's right hand). The quotations in chapter 1 draw from Psalm 2, 2 Samuel 7, Deuteronomy 32, Psalm 45, Psalm 102, and Psalm 110, which is a sweep of the Old Testament's royal and creation theology. Chapter 2 draws on Psalm 8, where humanity is crowned with glory and honor, and Hebrews shows that Jesus is the true Man who fulfills that calling. Later in the book, 2:17 prepares us for Hebrews 4:14-5:10 and 7:1-28.

STEP 6

Application

First, take the opening verse as a personal challenge: God has spoken. Do you treat his word as final? Resolve to read Scripture this week as the voice of the Son, not as a collection of tips.

Second, notice the warning about drifting. Few believers wake up one day and decide to abandon Christ. They stop praying, then stop reading, then stop gathering. Ask yourself which small habits are keeping you attentive to him, and which neglected habits are pulling you off course.

Third, if you fear death, in any of its forms, remember what verse 15 says. Christ has freed those who were enslaved. You can begin to say honestly that you are afraid and ask him to deal with it. He understands, and he has already won.

Fourth, take comfort that the Son is not embarrassed by you. Hebrews 2:11 says he is not ashamed to call you brother.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for speaking to you by his Son.

Ask him to keep you from drifting.

Ask him to open your ears to hear him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 821 · WEEK 118

Hebrews 3:1-4:13

Greater than Moses; the Sabbath rest remains

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 3:1-4:13. This is a long reading with a single theme: the danger of an unbelieving heart and the promise of God's rest. Keep your finger on the repeated phrase from Psalm 95, "Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts." It appears three times, and each time it presses on the reader.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Having shown that the Son is greater than angels, the author now compares him with Moses. For a Jewish audience, this was the more sensitive comparison. Moses was the lawgiver, the faithful servant, the man who spoke with God face to face. To suggest anyone is greater than Moses was bold. But the point is not to diminish Moses. It is to show that Moses himself pointed forward. Then the author turns to the wilderness generation, those who were delivered from Egypt but failed to enter the promised land because of unbelief. The warning is plain: do not follow their example. The promise of rest is still open.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Jesus is called the "apostle and high priest of our confession" (3:1). He is both sent from God and sent to God on our behalf.
2. Moses was faithful "as a servant in all God's house," but Christ is faithful "as a son over God's house" (3:5-6).
3. The house is built by God, and "we are his house if indeed we hold fast our confidence" (3:6).
4. Psalm 95:7-11 is quoted at length and applied to the readers: "Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts" (3:7-8).

5. The wilderness generation died because of unbelief and disobedience (3:16-19).
6. “A promise remains” of entering God’s rest (4:1), and the readers are told to strive to enter it (4:11).
7. The gospel was preached to the wilderness generation, but it did not benefit them because they were not united by faith with those who listened (4:2).
8. The word of God is described as living, active, and sharper than a two-edged sword, discerning the thoughts and intentions of the heart (4:12-13).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The comparison with Moses is one of respect and fulfillment. Both Moses and Jesus were faithful to God’s house, but they hold different positions. Moses was a servant in the house, and he served well. Jesus is the Son over the house, and in fact the builder of it. A house is always inferior to its builder, and a servant is always inferior to the son. This is not a criticism of Moses but a recognition that Moses’ faithful service was itself a testimony pointing forward to someone greater. Numbers 12:7 calls Moses faithful in all God’s house. Hebrews says: yes, and now the Son has come.

The conditional phrase in 3:6 deserves attention: “we are his house if indeed we hold fast our confidence.” This is the first appearance of a theme that runs through Hebrews. The author is not suggesting that believers earn their place in God’s house by perseverance. Rather, perseverance is how true faith shows itself. Those who belong to Christ will hold fast to him, and the warnings are God’s means of keeping them holding on.

Next the author reaches into Psalm 95 and applies it to his readers. The wilderness generation saw God’s mighty works. They were rescued from Egypt, fed with manna, and guided by the cloud. And yet they rebelled and tested God. The author’s diagnosis is clear: “an evil, unbelieving heart” that leads to falling away from the living God. The remedy is just as clear: exhort one another every day, as long as it is called “today,” so that none of you may be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin. Notice that the remedy is communal. Faith is not a private possession but something we guard together.

Chapter 4 develops the idea of rest. In Genesis 2, God rested on the seventh day. In Joshua, Israel entered the land. But Psalm 95, written centuries after Joshua, still speaks of a rest to enter “today.” The author’s reasoning is that if Joshua had given them the final rest, David would not have spoken of another day. Therefore “there remains a Sabbath rest for the people of God.” The rest is the fullness of salvation, communion with God, and relief from

striving to earn his favor. It is entered by faith, and it is fully enjoyed when Christ returns. We enter it now in part by trusting his finished work, and we will enter it fully in the new creation.

The urgency of verse 11, "Let us strive to enter that rest," sounds paradoxical. How do you strive to rest? The answer is that you strive against unbelief. The effort is to keep trusting, to keep coming back to Christ, and to refuse to harden your heart.

The section ends with a vivid picture of the word of God. It is living, active, and piercing. It exposes our hearts. Nothing is hidden from the one with whom we have to do. This is frightening if we are hiding, but it is also the basis for confidence, because the God who sees everything is the one who has provided a high priest.

STEP 5

Connection

The Moses comparison draws on Numbers 12 and Exodus 33:11, where Moses speaks with God face to face. The warning from Psalm 95 looks back to the rebellions at Massah and Meribah (Exodus 17, Numbers 14), which you read earlier in this plan. The theme of rest links Genesis 2:2, Exodus 20:8-11, Deuteronomy 12:9-10, and Joshua 21:44. Jesus himself offers this rest in Matthew 11:28-30. The living word of 4:12 echoes Isaiah 55:10-11 and prepares for the high priest passage that immediately follows.

STEP 6

Application

First, take the word "today" seriously. If you have been delaying obedience or repentance, today is the day to hear his voice. Choose one thing you know the Lord is asking of you, and do it.

Second, ask whether you are keeping up the daily exhortation Hebrews commands. Who is encouraging you in the faith? Who are you encouraging? If no one, take a first step this week toward someone in your church.

Third, think about rest. Many believers live as if salvation depends on constant effort. The Sabbath rest that remains is in part the rest of knowing that Christ has finished the work. Let your weekly rest day be a regular practice of trusting that.

Fourth, let Hebrews 4:12 shape how you read Scripture. Bring your heart to the word, expecting it to read you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Tell God that today you hear his voice, and ask him to soften your heart.

Confess where you have hardened your heart.

Thank him for the rest that remains.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 822 · WEEK 118

Hebrews 4:14-6:20

The great high priest; warning and assurance

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 38 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 4:14-6:20. The reading has three movements: the invitation to draw near to a sympathetic high priest, the qualifications of a priest, and a sober warning followed by a promise. Slow down at 6:4-8 and 6:9-12. The warning is real, and so is the author's confidence that his readers will persevere.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The author has spoken of Jesus as a great high priest. Now he stops to explain what that means. A priest stands between God and humanity, offering gifts and sacrifices on behalf of the people. In Israel the priests came from the tribe of Levi and the high priest from the line of Aaron. How could Jesus be a priest when he came from Judah? The author's answer introduces a mysterious figure from Genesis 14 and Psalm 110: Melchizedek. But before he can fully explain, he pauses to rebuke his readers for being slow to understand and to warn them against falling away. Then he ends the chapter with one of the most encouraging passages in the New Testament, on the certainty of God's promise.

STEP 3

Observation

1. 4:14-16 repeats the call to hold fast and gives the invitation to draw near to the throne of grace.
2. A high priest is chosen from among men to act on their behalf, and he can deal gently with the ignorant because he is beset by weakness himself (5:1-3).
3. Christ did not exalt himself to be a high priest. The Father called him with the words of Psalm 2 and Psalm 110 (5:5-6).

4. “In the days of his flesh,” Jesus offered up prayers with loud cries and tears, and “he learned obedience through what he suffered” (5:7-8).
5. The readers are called “dull of hearing” and still needing milk when they should be teachers (5:11-14).
6. 6:1-2 lists elementary teachings: repentance, faith, baptisms, laying on of hands, resurrection, and judgment.
7. 6:4-6 describes those who have been enlightened and tasted the heavenly gift, and then fallen away.
8. God swore by himself so that by two unchangeable things we might have strong encouragement, an anchor of the soul (6:13-20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The passage opens by repeating the invitation. The repetition is deliberate. Having just warned his readers, the author immediately offers hope. We have a high priest. Come to the throne of grace. Between the warning and the hope, he wants them to see that the answer to weakness is not retreat but nearness.

Chapter 5 sets out what a priest is and shows that Jesus qualifies. The two qualifications are sympathy and appointment. A high priest must be able to deal gently with those who stray because he knows his own weakness. Jesus meets this qualification not through sin but through suffering. “In the days of his flesh” refers to his earthly life, and verse 7 almost certainly points to Gethsemane. The Son offered prayers with loud cries and tears. This is the picture of a Savior who knows what it is to pray in agony. He “learned obedience through what he suffered.” This does not mean he was ever disobedient, but that he experienced obedience at its hardest cost. Having been “made perfect,” he became the source of eternal salvation to all who obey him. The second qualification is appointment: Jesus did not claim the office for himself. The Father called him, and Psalm 110:4 identifies his priesthood as “after the order of Melchizedek.”

At this point, the author’s thought stalls. He has much to say about Melchizedek, but his readers are sluggish. They should be teachers, yet they need to be taught the basics again. The rebuke is pastoral rather than cruel, and it is a challenge to every Christian: are you growing? Solid food belongs to the mature, those who have trained themselves by practice to distinguish good from evil.

Then comes the warning in 6:4-8. It is one of the most debated passages in the Bible, and honest interpreters disagree. The best reading, in line with the whole letter, is that the author describes those who have shared in the visible blessings of the church community,

heard the word, and tasted its power, but who then deliberately and finally reject Christ. For such a person, there is no second sacrifice. If Christ's sacrifice is rejected, nothing else remains. The author illustrates with farmland: the same rain falls on the field that bears fruit and the field that bears thorns. The question is what the field produces.

But the author does not leave his readers terrified. "Though we speak in this way, yet in your case, beloved, we feel sure of better things." The evidence of genuine faith is love shown through service to the saints, and the author wants them to keep it up to the end. Warnings and assurance are not enemies. The warnings are the means God uses to keep his people.

The chapter ends with a stunning image. God made a promise to Abraham and, because he had no one greater to swear by, swore by himself. A promise and an oath are two unchangeable things in which it is impossible for God to lie. This is the foundation of our confidence. Our hope is an anchor for the soul, firm and secure, and it enters "into the inner place behind the curtain" where Jesus has gone as a forerunner on our behalf. The anchor does not hold from the ship's side but from the harbor. Our hope is anchored in heaven, in the person of Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

The call of Jesus as priest from Psalm 110:4 links to your reading of Psalm 110 in this unit and to Genesis 14, where Abram met Melchizedek. The oath to Abraham comes from Genesis 22:16-17 and ties to the Abrahamic covenant you read in Unit 3. The picture of the field with thorns recalls Genesis 3:17-18 and Isaiah 5. Gethsemane in 5:7 anticipates Matthew 26, Mark 14, and Luke 22. The inner place behind the curtain points forward to the temple imagery of Hebrews 9-10.

STEP 6

Application

First, check your growth. Hebrews calls the readers to move beyond milk. What is one area of your faith, such as prayer, Scripture, or serving, in which you have stayed at the beginner level? Choose one concrete step to deepen it.

Second, treat the warning as a gift. If you feel a pull to drift or give up, do not hide it. Bring it to the Lord and to a trusted believer. The warnings exist to keep you close.

Third, rest in the oath of God. When you feel that your hold on God is slipping, remember that your hope does not rest in your grip but in his promise. The anchor holds you.

Fourth, draw near this week. Pray as someone who knows that Jesus has been where you are.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus that he is a high priest who knows what it is to weep and pray.
- Ask him to keep you from sluggishness and give you hope as an anchor.
- Draw near to his throne of grace and tell him what you need.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 823 · WEEK 118

Psalm 95

Today, if you hear his voice, Hebrews' warning psalm

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 95 aloud, slowly. Notice that it has two halves with very different moods. The first calls us to joyful worship, and the second turns suddenly to warning. Hebrews quoted the second half in the last two days of readings. Today you read the whole psalm in its original setting.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 95 was likely sung as a call to worship as pilgrims approached the temple. It begins with exuberant singing and ends with an alarm. The author of Hebrews took the final verses and made them the center of his warning in chapters 3 and 4. Reading the whole psalm helps us hear what he heard: worship and obedience are inseparable. To sing to the LORD with joy and then to harden your heart against his voice is a contradiction. The psalm asks us to come in, bow down, and listen.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The psalm opens with a call to sing and shout joyfully to "the rock of our salvation" (v. 1).
2. The LORD is called a great God and a great King above all gods (v. 3).
3. His is the depths of the earth, the heights of the mountains, the sea, and the dry land (vv. 4-5).
4. The invitation changes from singing to kneeling: "let us worship and bow down" (v. 6).
5. "He is our God, and we are the people of his pasture, and the sheep of his hand" (v. 7).
6. Verse 7 pivots mid-sentence: "Today, if you hear his voice, do not harden your hearts."

7. The warning cites Meribah and Massah, where Israel tested God in the wilderness (vv. 8-9).

8. The psalm ends with God's oath that the rebellious generation "shall not enter my rest" (v. 11).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The structure of Psalm 95 is a lesson in itself. It moves from praising God as Creator (vv. 1-5) to worshiping him as Shepherd (vv. 6-7a) to hearing him as Judge (vv. 7b-11). Each stage deepens the relationship. The God who made everything is also the God who made us his flock, and the God who speaks to us. Genuine worship always includes listening.

The first section calls for noise. Come into his presence with thanksgiving, make a joyful noise with songs of praise. The reason is given immediately: he is a great God, and the whole created order is in his hands. The depths of the earth and the peaks of the mountains both belong to him. The sea is his because he made it. Nothing is outside his reach.

Then the psalm calls for a different posture. The singing gives way to bowing. "Come, let us worship and bow down; let us kneel before the LORD, our Maker." The Creator is also our Maker, which means he has authority over us and care for us. Verse 7 puts it tenderly: "we are the people of his pasture, and the sheep of his hand." A good shepherd leads, and sheep follow. The psalmist is about to say what following requires.

The turn comes in the middle of verse 7: "Today, if you hear his voice." The relationship is not one of passive admiration. God speaks. The test of worship is the response to what he says. The warning that follows reaches back to the wilderness. At Meribah and Massah, the people grumbled for water even though they had seen the plagues and the sea divided. They tested God, demanding he prove himself again. For forty years God was grieved with that generation. The result was that they did not enter the rest he had promised.

The author of Hebrews uses this as a sober example for the church. Those who are the sheep of God's hand must listen to the shepherd. The call to today means that obedience cannot wait. Whenever the word of God comes, that is the day to respond.

Read as a whole, the psalm is not a contradiction between joy and fear. It shows that the deepest joy is found in submission to a God who is both great and good. The people who sing the loudest are the ones who also listen.

STEP 5

Connection

This psalm is quoted in Hebrews 3:7-11, 3:15, and 4:3-7. Its background is Exodus 17:1-7 and Numbers 20:1-13, where the people quarreled at Meribah and Massah. The shepherd imagery connects to Psalm 23 and Ezekiel 34, and finds its fulfillment in Jesus' words in John 10: "I am the good shepherd." The "rest" that Israel failed to enter looks back to Deuteronomy 12:9 and forward to the Sabbath rest of Hebrews 4.

STEP 6

Application

Use Psalm 95 as a Sunday morning pattern. Sing, kneel, and listen. If you are tempted to treat worship as entertainment, notice that the psalm calls for attention to God's voice. Before your next church service, ask the Lord to speak to you through the sermon, and be ready to obey.

Think about Meribah. Where are you demanding that God prove himself again? Are there areas where you have seen him provide and still grumble? Name one, and thank him instead.

Finally, remember that your shepherd has a name. The Lord who calls you his sheep is Jesus, who laid down his life for you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Worship God as rock of your salvation and shepherd of your soul.
- Tell him you want to hear his voice and not harden your heart.
- Thank him that he is your Maker.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 824 · WEEK 118

Psalm 40:1-10

I delight to do your will, the Son's voice

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 40:1-10 and then glance at Hebrews 10:5-10 where this psalm is quoted. The psalm is David's, but Hebrews hears it as the voice of the Son speaking to the Father. Read it twice, once as David's testimony and once as Christ's.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

In Hebrews 2 and 10, the author puts Old Testament psalms into the mouth of Jesus, treating them as the speech of the Son to the Father. Psalm 40 is one of these. In its original setting, David gives thanks for rescue from a pit and declares his joy in doing the will of God rather than offering mere sacrifices. Hebrews will take verses 6-8 and show that they find their fullest meaning in Christ, who came into the world to do the Father's will by offering his own body. Today we read the psalm ahead of that application, so we are ready to hear it when we get there.

STEP 3

Observation

1. David waited patiently for the LORD, and the LORD "inclined to me and heard my cry" (v. 1).
2. God lifted him from a "pit of destruction" and "the miry bog" and set his feet on a rock (v. 2).
3. God put "a new song in my mouth, a song of praise to our God" (v. 3).
4. Many will see and fear and put their trust in the LORD (v. 3).
5. "Sacrifice and offering you have not desired, but you have given me an open ear" (v. 6).
6. "Then I said, 'Behold, I have come; in the scroll of the book it is written of me'" (v. 7).

7. “I delight to do your will, O my God; your law is within my heart” (v. 8).
8. David has told the glad news of deliverance “in the great congregation” and has not restrained his lips (vv. 9-10).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with a testimony. David was in a pit, a place of helplessness, and he waited. The word suggests a long wait, and he does not complain but credits the LORD for hearing. The rescue is complete: the pit is replaced with a rock, and the mud with firm ground. And a new song fills his mouth. Rescue always produces praise.

Notice what happens next. David does not pretend that he can repay God. In verse 6, he says something surprising: “Sacrifice and offering you have not desired.” This was not a rejection of the sacrificial system, which God himself instituted, but a reminder that the sacrifices were never the point. What God wanted was an obedient heart. “You have given me an open ear.” The phrase may refer to a servant who willingly listens to his master. God wants those who hear him and respond.

Then David says, “Behold, I have come; in the scroll of the book it is written of me.” In David’s setting, this likely refers to the king’s duty described in the law (Deuteronomy 17:18-20). But Hebrews 10 reads it as the voice of Christ. When the Son came into the world, he said, “a body have you prepared for me” (the Greek translation of verse 6 that Hebrews quotes). The animal sacrifices could not take away sins. So Christ came, and he said: “I have come to do your will, O God.” By that will, we have been sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.

This is how the New Testament reads the Old. David’s experience is real, but it is also a shadow. His delight in doing God’s will is a faint picture of the perfect delight of the Son. His rescue from the pit is a hint of the great rescue from the grave. His proclamation in the great congregation looks ahead to the gospel going to the nations.

The last verses make an important point about testimony. David does not hide his deliverance. He proclaims God’s faithfulness and salvation and does not conceal his steadfast love. We are rescued so that others will see and trust.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 40:6-8 is quoted in Hebrews 10:5-7 and is the voice of Christ as he comes into the world. The “open ear” recalls Isaiah 50:4-5, the Servant who listens and does not turn back. The rescue from the pit resonates with Joseph in Genesis 37, Jonah 2, and Psalm 30. The

priority of obedience over sacrifice appears in 1 Samuel 15:22, Psalm 51:16-17, and Micah 6:6-8. “I delight to do your will” is the heart of Jesus’ own words in John 4:34 and Matthew 26:39.

STEP 6

Application

Think about the pit you have been rescued from. It may be sin, shame, fear, or something else. Write a short testimony of what God did, even just a few sentences. David did not hide his story, and your story may be what someone else needs to hear.

Examine your sense of delight. Do you obey God out of duty only, or is there any joy in it? Ask the Lord for the heart of the psalm: “your law is within my heart.” It is a gift, and Christ has given you his Spirit to produce it.

Finally, thank Jesus for saying what you could not say. He came to do the Father’s will. Because he did, you are free to approach.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for drawing you out of the pit and putting a new song in your mouth.

Thank him for the Son who came to do his will.

Ask him to give you delight in doing it.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

“He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high.”

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 825 · WEEK 118

Psalm 110

Priest forever after the order of Melchizedek

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Psalm · 7 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 110. It is only seven verses long, but it is the most quoted psalm in the New Testament. Read it slowly and mark the two oaths: God's promise to make the king sit at his right hand, and his oath that the king is also a priest forever. Note how the Lord speaks to "my Lord."

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

David wrote this psalm, and Jesus himself used it to stump the religious leaders. In Mark 12:35-37, Jesus asked how David could call the Messiah "my Lord" if the Messiah was merely David's son. The psalm contains a puzzle that is solved only in the person of Jesus. It pictures a king who is also a priest, which was forbidden in Israel, and who reigns at God's right hand over his enemies. Hebrews returns to this psalm repeatedly. In the unit you are reading now, Psalm 110 is the foundation of the argument that Christ is a high priest after the order of Melchizedek.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The LORD says to my Lord" (v. 1). David, the king, speaks of another who is his Lord.
2. The Lord is told to sit at the right hand of God until his enemies are made his footstool (v. 1).
3. The scepter of the king will extend from Zion, and he will rule in the midst of his enemies (v. 2).
4. His people offer themselves freely on the day of his power, "in holy garments" (v. 3).
5. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind: You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek" (v. 4).

6. The Lord at God's right hand will shatter kings on the day of his wrath and execute judgment among the nations (vv. 5-6).
7. The last verse is surprising: "He will drink from the brook by the way; therefore he will lift up his head" (v. 7).
8. The psalm combines two offices that never met in Israel, king and priest.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Psalm 110 is a royal psalm with an astonishing claim. The first verse is a conversation within God. "The LORD" (Yahweh) speaks to "my Lord" (Adonai), and invites him to sit at his right hand. David was the king of Israel, and no one was above him except God. So who is this Lord whom David calls his own? Jesus raised exactly this question, and the New Testament gives the answer: the Messiah is David's son and David's Lord. He is the descendant who is also the divine Son.

Verses 1-3 describe his reign. He sits at God's right hand, the place of authority, until his enemies are subdued. The conquest does not depend on his strength alone, because the LORD himself puts the enemies under his feet. Yet verse 2 adds that he rules from Zion in the midst of his enemies. He is already reigning, even though his enemies are not yet fully defeated. This is the "already and not yet" of the kingdom. And verse 3 says his people will volunteer on the day of his power. They are not conscripted but willing, clothed in holiness.

Verse 4 is the center of the psalm. "The LORD has sworn and will not change his mind: You are a priest forever after the order of Melchizedek." Two things stand out. First, God takes an oath. The Levitical priests were not appointed with an oath, but this priest is. Second, he is a priest forever, which means his priesthood has no end. The order of Melchizedek is not the Levitical order. It is the order of the priest-king who met Abraham in Genesis 14 and blessed him. This verse is the hinge of Hebrews 5-7. Hebrews argues that if there is a new priest of a different order, then the Levitical priesthood was never intended to be final.

The rest of the psalm describes judgment. The Lord at God's right hand will shatter kings and fill the places with corpses. This language is graphic, and it is meant to be. The reign of Christ includes the defeat of every evil power. Yet the final image is not one of bloodshed but of weariness: he drinks from a brook along the way and lifts up his head. The conquering king pauses to drink. He is human, and his victory is won in a body that gets thirsty.

The psalm gathers the two great themes of the book of Hebrews: Christ is a king who reigns, and a priest who intercedes. He sits because his work is finished, and he reigns because his enemies will be subdued.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 110:1 is quoted in Matthew 22:44, Acts 2:34-35, and Hebrews 1:13. Verse 4 is quoted in Hebrews 5:6, 7:17, and 7:21. The priest-king Melchizedek appears in Genesis 14:18-20, which you read in Unit 3. The Davidic promise of 2 Samuel 7 supports the royal side, and Zechariah 6:12-13 anticipates a priest who will sit and rule on his throne. The footstool imagery recalls Joshua 10:24 and 1 Corinthians 15:25.

STEP 6

Application

Pause to consider that the one who sits at God's right hand is also the one who prays for you. The reigning king and the sympathetic priest are the same person. Whatever you are afraid of, he rules over it, and whatever you are ashamed of, he has covered it.

Think about being one of his willing people. Verse 3 says they offer themselves freely. What is one thing you could offer him freely this week, such as time, money, or an act of service?

And take courage in the final image. Your Lord is not a distant figure who never grew tired. He knows weariness, and he lifts his head in victory.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Bow to Jesus as your king and priest forever.
- Thank him for the oath that cannot change.
- Ask him to rule over what resists him in your life.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 118

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

DAY 826 · WEEK 118

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you opened the book of Hebrews and read three Psalms that Hebrews draws on. Take a few moments today to be still before the Son you have been reading about. If you have time, reread Hebrews 1:1-4 slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"He is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high."

HEBREWS 1:3

REST

Meditation

Hebrews 1:3 is the center of the week. In a single sentence, it tells you who Jesus is and what he did.

"The radiance of the glory of God." Light streams from the sun and shares its nature. You cannot have the sun without the light. In the same way, the Son is not a created messenger who tells us about God. He is God's glory shining out. If you want to know what God is like, you look at Jesus.

"The exact imprint of his nature." A seal presses a mark into wax, and the mark reproduces every detail. The Son is the exact expression of the Father's being.

“He upholds the universe by the word of his power.” Everything that exists depends on him right now. The same Jesus who held a child and wept at a tomb is holding the galaxies together.

“After making purification for sins, he sat down.” This is the part most likely to change your week. He sat down. Priests in the old covenant stood daily, offering sacrifices that could never fully remove sin. Christ finished the work. There is nothing left for you to add to it. When you doubt that you are forgiven, remember that the one who made purification is seated, and the work is done.

Say the verse aloud. Carry it with you this week, especially into moments of anxiety. The Son who upholds the universe is the Son who has already dealt with your sin.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began Hebrews, the book that shows how the whole Old Testament points to Christ. You read the opening declaration that God has spoken finally in his Son, and you saw the Son’s superiority over angels. You heard the first warning against drifting, and you watched the Son become human to free us from the fear of death. You read the comparison of Jesus with Moses and the call to enter God’s rest while it is still called today. You saw that Jesus is a great high priest who can sympathize with our weakness, and you read the sober warning in chapter 6 alongside the anchor of God’s oath. In the Psalms, you sang Psalm 95, heard the voice of the Son in Psalm 40, and saw the priest-king of Psalm 110.

Behind it all stands a single truth: the Son is greater than everything that came before him, and he is for you.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

What does it mean to you that God has spoken finally and fully in his Son? Think about how you approach Scripture. Do you read the Old Testament as incomplete or as a story that moves toward Christ? What would change if you read every page as pointing to him?

How does Jesus’ priesthood change the way you approach God in prayer? Hebrews 4:14-16 says he understands your weakness, has passed through the heavens, and invites you to draw near. Think of a specific struggle or failure you have been reluctant to bring to God. What would it look like to bring it to him today, in the name of the priest who knows what it is like to be tempted?

Where are you most tempted to drift, harden your heart, or neglect your salvation? The warnings of Hebrews are meant to keep you close to Christ, not to frighten you away. Name one practice that could help you stay attentive this coming week, and one person who could encourage you in it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the finished work of his Son.

Worship Jesus as the radiance of God's glory.

Rest in all he has done.

DAY 827 · WEEK 119

Hebrews 7:1-28

Melchizedek, the better priest

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 7:1-28, and if you can, reread Genesis 14:17-20 first. The argument here is dense, so read it twice if needed. The core claim is simple: if perfection had been possible through the Levitical priesthood, there would have been no need for another priest to arise.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Last week the author mentioned Melchizedek and then paused to rebuke his readers. Now he returns to the subject and gives it a full chapter. Why does this obscure figure from Genesis matter so much? Because he is the key to understanding how Jesus, who descended from the tribe of Judah and not Levi, can serve as a priest at all. The readers were Jewish Christians who revered the Levitical priesthood as God's own institution. The author does not belittle it. He shows that Scripture itself, in Genesis 14 and Psalm 110, pointed beyond it. This chapter argues that the old priesthood was a temporary shadow, and that the permanent reality has come in Christ.

STEP 3

Observation

1. Melchizedek is "king of righteousness" and "king of peace," king of Salem and priest of God Most High (vv. 1-2).
2. He is described as "without father or mother or genealogy, having neither beginning of days nor end of life, but resembling the Son of God" (v. 3).
3. Abraham gave him a tenth of the spoils, and Melchizedek blessed Abraham. "It is beyond dispute that the inferior is blessed by the superior" (v. 7).
4. Levi, still in the loins of Abraham, paid tithes through him (vv. 9-10).

5. If perfection had come through the Levitical priesthood, why would another priest arise "after the order of Melchizedek" (v. 11)?
6. A change of priesthood requires a change of law (v. 12), and Jesus descended from Judah, a tribe with no priestly role (v. 14).
7. Jesus became a priest "by the power of an indestructible life" and not by ancestry (v. 16).
8. "He always lives to make intercession for them" (v. 25), and he is "holy, innocent, unstained, separated from sinners" (v. 26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

This chapter is an exercise in careful Bible reading. The author takes a few verses of Genesis and a single line of Psalm 110 and draws out their full implications. His argument has three steps.

First, Melchizedek is greater than Abraham. Abraham gave him a tenth and received his blessing. In ancient culture, the one who blesses is superior, and the one who tithes is inferior. Since Levi descended from Abraham, the whole Levitical priesthood, in a sense, tithed to Melchizedek in Abraham. So Melchizedek's priesthood has a greater standing than Aaron's.

Second, the very existence of the Melchizedek priest in Psalm 110, centuries after Moses, shows that the Levitical system was incomplete. If the old priesthood could bring perfection, meaning a full and lasting cleansing of conscience and access to God, then no one would have needed to speak of a different priest. But God did speak of one. A new priesthood implies a new law, because the priesthood and the law are tied together. And that is exactly what the new covenant is. The author is not saying the law was bad, but that it was provisional, preparing for something better.

Third, Jesus is that priest. His qualification is not ancestry but "the power of an indestructible life." The Levitical priests died and were replaced, one after another. Jesus lives forever, and therefore his priesthood does not pass to anyone else. Verse 24 says "he holds his priesthood permanently." The practical result is verse 25: "he is able to save to the uttermost those who draw near to God through him, since he always lives to make intercession for them." This is one of the most comforting verses in the New Testament. Uttermost means completely, to the end. The saving power of Christ does not run out, and his intercession does not stop.

What about the description of Melchizedek as having no father, mother, or genealogy? The author is not saying that Melchizedek was a mysterious immortal. He is reading the silence of Genesis. The narrative gives no parentage and records no death. Therefore, as presented in Scripture, he resembles the eternal Son of God. He is a type, a living picture drawn by the Holy Spirit, and the original is Christ.

Verses 26-28 sum it up. We needed a high priest who is holy, innocent, and unstained, who has no need to offer sacrifices for his own sins first, and who offered one sacrifice once for all when he offered up himself. The old priests had to offer for themselves and then for the people, day after day. Jesus did it once, and it was enough.

STEP 5

Connection

The backbone of this chapter is Genesis 14:17-20 and Psalm 110:4. The tithe and blessing look back to Genesis 12:2-3 and forward to the new covenant in Hebrews 8. The Levitical priesthood was established in Exodus 28-29 and Leviticus 8-9. Isaiah 53:12 pictures the Servant who makes intercession for transgressors, and Romans 8:34 gives the same truth about Christ's present ministry.

STEP 6

Application

First, take comfort in "to the uttermost." If you suspect that your sin or weakness is too much for Christ, this verse says otherwise. He saves completely and perpetually.

Second, let the phrase "he always lives to make intercession" shape your prayers. When you do not know what to say, remember that someone is already speaking for you.

Third, notice that Hebrews treats the Old Testament as a book about Christ. Next time you come across a puzzling Old Testament passage, ask: how might this point forward to Jesus? You may not always find the answer, but the question will make you a better reader.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus that he is your priest forever and always lives to pray for you.

Tell him what you need him to intercede for.

Thank him that he saves you to the uttermost.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

“Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God.”

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 828 · WEEK 119

Hebrews 8:1-9:28

The better covenant; the better sacrifice

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 8:1-9:28. This is the theological heart of the letter. Look for the contrast between the earthly tent and the heavenly one, and between the blood of animals and the blood of Christ. Read the quotation of Jeremiah 31:31-34 in 8:8-12 carefully. You encountered it earlier in this plan on the covenant day.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The author has argued that Christ is a priest of a better order. Now he states the main point: we have such a high priest, who is seated in heaven, and he serves in a better sanctuary under a better covenant. This section is where the language of Hebrews becomes most temple-centered, and it can feel unfamiliar. But the author is working with the elements his readers knew well: the tabernacle, the Day of Atonement, and the blood of sacrifices. He shows that these were copies and shadows, and that Christ has entered the reality. This is the heart of how the old covenant fits with the new.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The main point: we have a high priest who is seated at the right hand of the throne in heaven (8:1).
2. The earthly priests serve “a copy and shadow of the heavenly things” (8:5).
3. Christ has obtained a ministry “as much more excellent” as the covenant he mediates is better, “enacted on better promises” (8:6).
4. Jeremiah 31:31-34 is quoted in full, with its promise of a new covenant, laws on hearts, and sins remembered no more (8:8-12).
5. “In speaking of a new covenant, he makes the first one obsolete” (8:13).

6. The first tent had its furnishings, and only the high priest entered the Most Holy Place, once a year, with blood (9:1-7).
7. The Holy Spirit signified that the way into the holy places was not yet opened (9:8).
8. "Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness of sins" (9:22). Christ appeared "once for all at the end of the ages to put away sin by the sacrifice of himself" (9:26).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The language of copy and shadow is crucial. The author does not say the tabernacle was a mistake. It was designed by God, built according to the pattern shown to Moses. But a pattern is not the thing itself. A shadow tells you something real about the object that casts it, but you cannot embrace a shadow. The tabernacle taught Israel that God is holy, that sin is serious, that blood is needed, and that a mediator must stand between God and humanity. All of that was true. But it could not permanently deal with sin.

Chapter 8 then quotes Jeremiah's promise, the longest Old Testament quotation in the New Testament. God says the days are coming when he will make a new covenant. Its features are striking. The law will be written on hearts. Everyone will know the LORD, from the least to the greatest. And God will remember sins no more. The author's comment is quietly devastating: by speaking of a "new" covenant, God has marked the old one as obsolete and ready to vanish. The old covenant did not fail because God failed. Jeremiah 31:32 says Israel broke it. The new covenant is better because it deals with the heart problem that the old one could only expose.

Chapter 9 describes the day of atonement in detail. Once a year, the high priest entered the Most Holy Place carrying blood for himself and the people. The Holy Spirit was teaching something by this arrangement: the way into God's presence was not yet open. The curtain remained. The sacrifices could cleanse the outside, providing ceremonial purity, but they could not clear the conscience.

Then the contrast arrives in verse 11: "But when Christ appeared as a high priest of the good things that have come..." He entered not an earthly tent but the heavenly sanctuary, not with the blood of goats and calves but with his own blood. And he did so once for all, securing an eternal redemption. If the blood of animals could sanctify for the purification of the flesh, how much more will the blood of Christ cleanse our conscience from dead works to serve the living God. The cleansing is deeper because the sacrifice is greater.

The author uses a legal image in verses 16-17. A covenant is like a will. It takes effect when the one who made it dies. Christ's death put the new covenant into effect, and he mediates its promised inheritance to those who are called.

The chapter ends with a striking picture. Humans die once and then face judgment, so Christ was offered once to bear the sins of many, and he will appear a second time, not to deal with sin but to save those who are eagerly waiting for him. The first coming dealt with sin. The second will bring salvation in its fullness.

STEP 5

Connection

This chapter draws on Exodus 25-40, Leviticus 16 (the Day of Atonement), and Jeremiah 31:31-34, which you studied on the covenant day earlier. The blood of the covenant echoes Exodus 24:8, and Jesus used the same language at the Last Supper in Luke 22:20. The "second appearing" links to Acts 1:11, the ascension passage, and to Titus 2:13.

STEP 6

Application

First, let verse 14 reach your conscience. If you still carry guilt over sins God has forgiven, remember that Christ's blood does not just cover the past. It cleanses the conscience. Confess what is true, and then rest in what is done.

Second, notice the promise that God's law is written on hearts. If you have felt that obedience is a burden, ask the Holy Spirit to make God's commands your delight, as he promised.

Third, take comfort in the phrase "once for all." There is no sacrifice left for you to make to earn forgiveness. Serve God because you are cleansed, not to become clean.

Fourth, live in expectation. Christ will appear a second time. Ask yourself how your week would change if you were eagerly waiting for him.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the new covenant sealed with the blood of his Son.
- Ask him to cleanse your conscience from dead works.
- Ask him to write his law on your heart.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

“Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God.”

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 829 · WEEK 119

Hebrews 10:1-39

The shadow vs. the reality; the new and living way

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 39 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 10:1-39. Notice the shift from argument to exhortation around verse 19. The first half completes the case that Christ's sacrifice is final. The second half draws three "let us" conclusions for how to live. Pay attention to verses 26-31, which are sobering, and verses 32-39, which are full of encouragement.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The author has spent several chapters building his case for the better priest, better covenant, and better sacrifice. Chapter 10 brings the argument to its climax and then turns on a hinge into the application. The first section returns to the idea of shadow and reality, and the second part invites readers to enter by the new and living way. Throughout, there is a pastoral concern. These Christians had faced hostility and lost property. They were tempted to withdraw. The author wants them to see that the cost of leaving Christ is far greater than the cost of staying.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The law has "a shadow of the good things to come," not the true form of these realities (10:1).
2. If animal sacrifices could cleanse, they would have stopped. Instead they are "a reminder of sins every year" (10:2-3).
3. "It is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins" (10:4).
4. Psalm 40:6-8 is quoted as the words of Christ: "a body have you prepared for me… Behold, I have come to do your will, O God" (10:5-7).

5. “By a single offering he has perfected for all time those who are being sanctified” (10:14).

6. We have confidence to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus, “by the new and living way that he opened for us through the curtain, that is, through his flesh” (10:19-20).

7. Three exhortations follow: “let us draw near,” “let us hold fast,” and “let us consider how to stir up one another to love and good works” (10:22-24).

8. “We are not of those who shrink back and are destroyed, but of those who have faith and preserve their souls” (10:39).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The opening of chapter 10 distills the argument. The law offered a shadow, not the image itself. If the sacrifices of the Day of Atonement could have perfected the worshipers, they would have been offered no more. But the very repetition showed their limitation. Each year the people were reminded of their sins, because the blood of bulls and goats could not take sin away.

Then comes the voice of Christ in Psalm 40. The Son speaks to the Father at the moment of the incarnation: sacrifices and offerings you did not desire, but a body you prepared for me. “Behold, I have come to do your will.” The will of God is that we be sanctified through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all. This is the center of the chapter. A body was prepared so that a sacrifice could be made that actually works.

The contrast between the standing priests and the seated Christ is the author’s recurring image. Every priest stands daily, offering the same sacrifices that can never take away sins. But Christ, having offered a single sacrifice for sins for all time, sat down. And because of that single offering, he has perfected for all time those who are being sanctified. Notice the tenses. The perfection is complete, and the sanctification is ongoing. Believers are already fully cleansed in their standing and are still being made holy in their experience. The new covenant promise is repeated: “I will remember their sins and their lawless deeds no more.” And where there is forgiveness, there is no longer any offering for sin.

Now the hinge. Verses 19-25 begin with “therefore” and turn argument into invitation. The curtain that separated humanity from God’s presence has been opened through Christ’s flesh. In the temple, the curtain was torn from top to bottom at the crucifixion (Matthew 27:51), and the author uses this image: the curtain is his flesh. We can enter with confidence,

with hearts sprinkled clean and bodies washed with pure water. The three exhortations follow: draw near in faith, hold fast the confession of hope without wavering, and stir one another up to love and good works, "not neglecting to meet together."

Verses 26-31 are among the most sobering in the New Testament. If we deliberately go on sinning after receiving the knowledge of the truth, no sacrifice remains. The author is describing those who persistently reject Christ and treat his blood as common. To spurn the Son is a more serious offense than breaking the law of Moses. "It is a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God." The point is not to undermine assurance but to underline how much is at stake.

But he ends with encouragement. He reminds them of their former courage: they endured a hard struggle, were publicly exposed to reproach, and joyfully accepted the plundering of their property, since they knew they had a better and abiding possession. He tells them not to throw away their confidence. "For you have need of endurance." The one who is coming will come and will not delay. "The righteous shall live by faith." And then comes the closing assurance: "We are not of those who shrink back and are destroyed, but of those who have faith and preserve their souls."

STEP 5

Connection

This chapter quotes Psalm 40 (Day 824), Jeremiah 31 (Day 828), Deuteronomy 32:35-36, and Habakkuk 2:3-4. The "new and living way" through the curtain links to Exodus 26:31-33, where the veil separated the holy place from the most holy place, and to the tearing of the veil in Matthew 27:51. Paul quotes Habakkuk 2:4 in Romans 1:17 and Galatians 3:11. The call to meet together prepares for the next day's doctrinal reading.

STEP 6

Application

First, accept the invitation. You have confidence to enter God's presence by the blood of Jesus. If you have been treating prayer as a duty or a risk, remember that the way is open.

Second, examine your commitment to gathering with the church. Verse 25 does not treat attendance as optional. Ask who in your church needs your encouragement, and make a plan to talk to them this week.

Third, think about endurance. The original readers had lost property for Christ. What have you been willing to lose? What have you been unwilling to risk? Ask the Lord for courage.

Fourth, take verse 38 as a daily motto: the righteous shall live by faith.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for opening the way through the curtain by his body.
- Draw near with a true heart in full assurance, and tell him so.
- Ask him to help you hold fast and encourage others.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 830 · WEEK 119

Acts 2:42-47; Hebrews 10:24-25

Covenanted community

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Doctrine · 8 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Acts 2:42-47 and Hebrews 10:24-25. These two short passages describe the same reality from different angles: the first shows what a gathered church looked like in the days after Pentecost, and the second urges believers to keep meeting. Read them together and ask: what does it mean to belong to a church, not just to attend one?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Yesterday's reading ended with an exhortation that tends to be passed over quickly: "not neglecting to meet together, as is the habit of some." Today we pause to think about what that means. Many new believers assume Christianity is primarily a private relationship with God, and that church is a helpful extra. The Bible does not present it that way. From the first day of the church's life, those who believed were devoted to a community. The people of the new covenant are a family, a body, and a household. This pause examines the biblical basis for committed membership in a local church.

STEP 3

Observation

1. The first Christians "devoted themselves to the apostles" teaching and the fellowship, to the breaking of bread and the prayers' (Acts 2:42).
2. They had "all things in common" and sold possessions to give to anyone in need (2:44-45).
3. They met "day by day," both in the temple and in homes (2:46).
4. The Lord added to their number "day by day those who were being saved" (2:47). Salvation and community are joined.

5. Hebrews 10:24 says to "consider how to stir up one another to love and good works." The verb is intentional and active.
6. Verse 25 warns against "neglecting to meet together, as is the habit of some." Even in the first century, some were drifting away.
7. The motivation is eschatological: "as you see the Day drawing near."
8. Both passages assume a visible, identifiable community. Someone could be "added" to it and someone could "neglect" it.

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

A local church is a gathered community of baptized believers who have covenanted together to worship God, hear his word, observe the ordinances, encourage one another, and carry out the mission of Christ in a particular place. Membership in such a church is how a Christian visibly and formally commits to the body of Christ.

The New Testament does not use the exact phrase "church membership," but it describes the reality. In the book of Acts, believers are "added" to the church (2:41, 47). Some in Jerusalem "joined" the disciples, and others "dared not join them" (5:13). In 1 Corinthians 5, Paul tells the church to remove an unrepentant man from their fellowship, which presupposes a recognizable body with a boundary. In 2 Corinthians 2:6, Paul speaks of a punishment "by the majority." In Hebrews 13:17, believers are told to obey and submit to their leaders, "for they are keeping watch over your souls." You cannot be accountable to leaders you do not know or follow leaders you have not identified. Peter says the elders are to shepherd "the flock of God that is among you" (1 Peter 5:2). A flock has a defined membership.

Why does it matter? First, because Christ loves the church. Ephesians 5:25 says he "gave himself up for her." To neglect the church is to neglect the bride of Christ. Second, because the Christian life is lived in community. The New Testament is full of "one another" commands: love one another, bear one another's burdens, forgive one another, teach and admonish one another, confess your sins to one another, and encourage one another. These commands cannot be obeyed alone. Third, because God gave us spiritual gifts for the common good (1 Corinthians 12:7). If you are not part of a body, your gifts go unused and others miss what God intended for them. Fourth, because the church exercises discipline and gives assurance. Jesus gave the church authority in Matthew 16 and 18 to affirm credible professions of faith and to correct those who stray. Baptism and the Lord's Supper are practiced within the church. Finally, because a committed church is a witness to the world. Jesus said in John 13:35, "By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another."

What should membership look like? A member commits to regular attendance and participation, to supporting the church with time, gifts, and money, to submitting to the leadership and the discipline of the church, to pursuing peace and unity, and to serving others. The church, in turn, commits to teach, pray for, care for, and shepherd its members. This is a covenant, and it echoes the covenants that have run throughout the Bible.

A few cautions are in order. No church is perfect, and joining one means joining a community of imperfect people. Some have been wounded by churches, and that grief is real. But the answer is to find a healthy church, one that preaches the gospel faithfully, practices the ordinances rightly, and cares for its members. Membership is not a requirement for salvation. It is the fruit of salvation and the normal setting of Christian growth.

A final word to those who feel they can follow Jesus privately. Scripture knows no solitary Christians. When God saves a person, he adds them to a body. The hand cannot say to the foot, "I have no need of you" (1 Corinthians 12:21). And the Christian who drifts from the gathering is at risk, because we are not designed to persevere alone.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Acts 2 gives us a picture of the church in its earliest and freshest form. After Pentecost, three thousand people were baptized and added. The text immediately describes what they did: they devoted themselves. The verb implies persistence and commitment, not a casual drop-in. Four things marked them: teaching, fellowship, the breaking of bread, and prayer. These are the basic activities of a church in every age.

The fellowship described in the passage was practical. They shared what they had. They saw a need, and they met it. This was not a forced system but a spontaneous generosity that grew from the gospel. They met both in the temple courts and from house to house. The large gatherings and the small gatherings were both necessary. They ate with glad and generous hearts, praising God. And the result was that outsiders were drawn in, and "the Lord added to their number day by day those who were being saved."

Hebrews 10:24-25 addresses the same church a generation later, when the early enthusiasm was fading. Some were neglecting to meet. Perhaps because of persecution, or fatigue, or doubt. The author's response is not a rebuke of those individuals but a call to the community. "Consider how to stir up one another." The word "stir up" is literally "provoke," and it is used elsewhere for sharp irritation. Here it is used positively: we are to provoke one another to love and good works. That requires being close enough to know what the other person needs.

The author gives the reason: “as you see the Day drawing near.” The more the return of Christ approaches, the more believers should gather, not less. The temptation in hard times is to withdraw. The biblical answer is to draw closer.

It is worth noticing that these two passages answer two different objections. Acts 2 answers the person who says, “I can worship God just as well on my own.” The earliest believers did not think of discipleship as a solo project. Everything they were devoted to, the teaching, the meals, the prayers, and the sharing of possessions, required other people. Hebrews 10 answers a different objection: “I’ve been hurt, tired, or disappointed, so I’ll step back for a while.” The author does not deny that the Christian life is hard. He says that the answer to hardship is more community, because a believer who is isolated is vulnerable to the “deceitfulness of sin” (3:13) in a way that a believer surrounded by brothers and sisters is not.

Notice also what the gathering is for. It is not first about the programs or the building. Acts 2 centers on the apostles’ teaching, so the word of God sits at the heart. It includes the Lord’s Supper (“the breaking of bread”), where Christ’s sacrifice is proclaimed. It includes prayer. In other words, the church gathers around Christ and his gospel. Hebrews 10 puts the gathering inside a larger argument about Christ’s priesthood. We meet because we have a great high priest, because the curtain is open, and because we need each other to keep holding fast. The church is where the new covenant becomes visible. Membership is not an add-on to the gospel. It is the shape of life together under the gospel.

STEP 5

Connection

The church as a covenant community extends the covenant structure studied earlier in this plan. Israel was the assembly (qahal) of the LORD, and the church is the assembly of the new covenant (Hebrews 12:22-24). The body language of 1 Corinthians 12 and Romans 12, the household language of Ephesians 2:19 and 1 Timothy 3:15, and the shepherding language of 1 Peter 5 all assume a defined community. Matthew 18:15-20 describes the church’s authority, and Acts 20:28 charges elders to care for the flock.

STEP 6

Application

If you are not yet a member of a local church, consider this week how to take the next step. Talk to the pastor or a leader about what membership involves. If you are a member, ask whether you are living out your commitment. Do you attend regularly? Do you serve? Do you know others well enough to encourage them?

Choose one person in your church to stir up this week. Send a message, offer to meet, or invite them to a meal. Ask how you can pray for them. This is how the "one another" commands get lived out.

If you have been hurt by a church, bring that pain honestly to the Lord. He loves his church, and he can heal what has been broken. Pray for a community where you can be known and loved.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for loving his church and giving himself for her.
- Ask him to make you a faithful member who meets with his people.
- Ask him to show you how to encourage someone this week.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 831 · WEEK 119

Hebrews 11:1-40

Faith's hall of fame

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 40 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 11:1-40. This chapter is often called the "hall of faith," and it is worth reading it as a story rather than a list. Notice how each person acts on a promise they cannot yet see. As you read, pay attention to how the chapter begins with a definition and ends with a surprise: none of them received what was promised.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The last chapter ended with a call to endurance: "the righteous shall live by faith." Chapter 11 is the author's answer to the question, what does that look like? He walks through the Old Testament, and the people you have been reading about in this plan appear one after another: Abel, Enoch, Noah, Abraham, Sarah, Isaac, Jacob, Joseph, Moses, Rahab, and many more. Their stories are different, but their faith has the same shape. They believed God's word about what he would do, and they lived accordingly. For readers who were tired and tempted to quit, this was a gallery of encouragement. For us, it is a review of much of the Old Testament through the lens of faith.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen" (11:1).
2. "By faith we understand that the universe was created by the word of God" (11:3).
3. Abel, Enoch, and Noah are praised for worship, walking with God, and obedience on the basis of a warning about what was not yet seen (11:4-7).
4. Abraham went out "not knowing where he was going" and lived as a sojourner in tents (11:8-10).

5. These all "died in faith, not having received the things promised, but having seen them and greeted them from afar" (11:13).
6. They desired "a better country, that is, a heavenly one," and God "has prepared for them a city" (11:16).
7. Verses 32-38 list others whose faith led to victory and others whose faith led to suffering, torture, and exile.
8. "God had provided something better for us, that apart from us they should not be made perfect" (11:40).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The chapter begins with a definition. Faith is the assurance of things hoped for and the conviction of things not seen. It is not a leap in the dark or wishful thinking. It is confidence in what God has said, which stands on his character and promise. Faith gives substance to what is hoped for and evidence for what cannot yet be seen.

The author illustrates this with an extended survey. Some things stand out. First, faith always responds to a word. Noah heard a warning. Abraham heard a call. Moses heard a promise. Faith is not generated from within. It is a response to God speaking. Second, faith acts. Abel offered. Noah built. Abraham went. Sarah considered him faithful who had promised. Faith is not merely inward conviction. It is obedience.

Third, faith endures. Notice verses 13-16. These people lived as strangers and exiles on the earth. They could have returned to the land they left, but they desired a better country. Because of that, "God is not ashamed to be called their God." Faith is not fully satisfied by this world. It looks for a city with foundations, whose designer and builder is God.

The most remarkable examples come in verses 17-19. Abraham, when tested, offered up Isaac, "considering that God was able even to raise him from the dead." You read this in Genesis 22. The author reveals what was going on in Abraham's mind: he believed in resurrection before it happened. That is the kind of faith that makes sense of an impossible command.

Verses 32-38 are striking. The author, running short of time, summarizes: some by faith conquered kingdoms, shut the mouths of lions, and escaped the edge of the sword. Others by faith were tortured, mocked, imprisoned, and killed. "Of whom the world was not worthy." Both groups are commended for faith. Faith is not a guarantee of success or comfort. Sometimes it leads to victory in this life, and sometimes to suffering. In either case, God honors it.

Then comes the surprise. “And all these, though commended through their faith, did not receive what was promised, since God had provided something better for us.” The Old Testament saints waited, and we are living in the fulfillment of what they longed for. Christ has come. And they will not be made perfect without us. The family of faith is one, and its completion awaits all of God’s people together.

This is the proper way to read the chapter. It does not tell you to be like the heroes. It tells you that God was faithful to them, and that he will be faithful to you. The “cloud of witnesses” in the next chapter will be exactly these people, and they are cheering for you to run the race that they have finished.

STEP 5

Connection

Nearly every person in this chapter appears in the Old Testament stories you have read in this plan: Genesis 4 (Abel), Genesis 5 (Enoch), Genesis 6-9 (Noah), Genesis 12-22 (Abraham and Sarah), Genesis 27-50 (Isaac, Jacob, Joseph), and Exodus (Moses). The definition of faith recalls Genesis 15:6. The better country anticipates Revelation 21-22. The unnamed sufferers of verses 35-38 recall the prophets and the Maccabean martyrs, and the idea of God’s people waiting for the whole body to be completed anticipates Revelation 6:9-11.

STEP 6

Application

First, think about how you define faith. If you think of it as a feeling or a general positive attitude, let this chapter correct you. Faith is trusting what God has said and acting on it.

Second, identify one area where God has given you a clear word, in Scripture, but you have not yet acted. It might be forgiving someone, giving generously, or sharing the gospel. Take one concrete step.

Third, be encouraged that faith does not always bring ease. If you are suffering and wondering whether you are doing something wrong, notice the second half of the list. Faithful people suffered too. God was not ashamed of them.

Fourth, look at the “better” in verse 40. We have received what they longed for. Thank God that you live on this side of the cross.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God for faith that trusts his word when you cannot see the outcome.

Name a person from the chapter whose faith you want to follow.

Thank him that they all point to Jesus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 832 · WEEK 119

Hebrews 12:1-29

Run the race; Mount Zion; the discipline of God

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 29 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 12:1-29. Chapter 12 begins with the image of a race and ends with a vision of the heavenly Jerusalem. Pay attention to the word "therefore" in verse 1 and to the contrast between Mount Sinai and Mount Zion in verses 18-24. Notice also how the discipline of the Father is presented as love and not rejection.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The great chapter on faith led to a great crowd of witnesses, and now the author brings the argument home with a series of commands. These Christians are tired and discouraged, and they have faced hardship. The author does not offer a quick fix. Instead, he gives them three things: a model to follow in Jesus, a perspective on suffering as the discipline of a loving Father, and a vision of where they are going. The chapter ends with a sober reminder that the God who spoke at Sinai still speaks, and that he is a consuming fire.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Since we are surrounded by so great a cloud of witnesses, let us also lay aside every weight, and sin which clings so closely" (12:1).
2. "Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith" (12:1-2).
3. Jesus endured the cross "for the joy that was set before him," despising the shame, and is seated at God's right hand (12:2).
4. Readers are told to "consider him who endured from sinners such hostility against himself, so that you may not grow weary or fainthearted" (12:3).
5. Proverbs 3:11-12 is quoted: "the Lord disciplines the one he loves" (12:5-6).

6. God disciplines us “for our good, that we may share his holiness” (12:10).
7. Mount Sinai (fear, fire, trembling) is contrasted with Mount Zion (the heavenly Jerusalem, angels, the church of the firstborn, Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant) (12:18-24).
8. “Our God is a consuming fire,” and we are receiving “a kingdom that cannot be shaken” (12:28-29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The race image is familiar, but the details matter. The race is not a sprint but a long endurance run. Runners strip off whatever slows them. Hebrews names two things: weights and sin. A weight is not necessarily sinful. It may be a good thing that hinders you. Sin is the thing that clings so closely, and it is to be put off entirely. Both must go if the race is to be run well.

The center of the passage is verse 2. We run “looking to Jesus.” The Greek verb means to fix your eyes, to look away from everything else. He is the founder (the pioneer, the one who blazed the trail) and the perfecter (the one who brings it to completion) of our faith. He is not only an example of faith but the source and goal of it. And what did he do? He endured the cross for the joy set before him. Joy and cross are not contradictory. The cross was the path to the joy of redeeming his people and sitting at the Father’s right hand. He despised the shame, meaning he counted it as nothing compared to the joy. This is why we can endure: the one who ran first has finished and is waiting.

Then the author addresses the problem of suffering. The readers had suffered, but not unto blood. He reaches for Proverbs 3 and reminds them that they are sons. Discipline is a sign of a father’s love. This word “discipline” is not just punishment but training, the whole process of upbringing. A father who does not discipline his children shows indifference. God disciplines us “for our good, that we may share his holiness.” It is painful at the moment, but it yields “the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it.” Notice that this does not say all suffering is punishment for specific sins. It says that God uses hardship for our growth.

The final half of the chapter contrasts two mountains. At Sinai, the people trembled. There was darkness, gloom, and a voice so terrifying that they begged not to hear it. Even Moses said, “I tremble with fear.” But the Christian has not come to Sinai. We have come to Mount Zion, the city of the living God, with innumerable angels in festal gathering, the assembly of the firstborn, God the judge of all, the spirits of the righteous made perfect, and Jesus, the

mediator of a new covenant, and the sprinkled blood that speaks a better word than the blood of Abel. Abel's blood cried out for vengeance, and Christ's blood cries out for forgiveness.

Yet the author does not let the contrast lull anyone into complacency. "See that you do not refuse him who is speaking." If Israel did not escape when they refused the one who warned on earth, how much less will we escape if we reject the one who warns from heaven? The shaking of heaven and earth will remove everything temporary, and only what is unshakable will remain. We are receiving that kingdom. Therefore, let us offer worship with reverence and awe, "for our God is a consuming fire."

STEP 5

Connection

Abel appears in Genesis 4 and again in 11:4. Sinai's terrors are described in Exodus 19-20 and Deuteronomy 4-5. The shaking of the heavens and earth is from Haggai 2:6. Proverbs 3:11-12 supplies the discipline text. The "heavenly Jerusalem" anticipates Revelation 21, and the "consuming fire" comes from Deuteronomy 4:24. You read Psalm 95 earlier this week, and its warning against refusing God's voice stands behind verse 25.

STEP 6

Application

First, ask what weights and sins are slowing your race. A weight might be a habit, a relationship, or a pursuit that is not wrong in itself but is dulling your devotion. Name one thing to lay aside this week.

Second, when you grow weary, fix your eyes on Jesus. Read one of the Gospel accounts of the cross and consider what he endured for you.

Third, reread a current hardship through the lens of verse 6. If you are in a season of difficulty, ask what God might be teaching you. You may not know. But trust that he does not waste suffering.

Fourth, worship with reverence. The God who welcomes you is also the God who is a consuming fire. Let that shape how you come into church this Sunday.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Ask God to help you run the race with endurance, eyes on Jesus.

Tell him what weight or sin you need to lay aside.

Thank him for his discipline as a Father.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 119

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."

HEBREWS 12:1-2

DAY 833 · WEEK 119

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

Today there is no new reading. This week you read the heart of Hebrews, the better priest, the better covenant, and the better sacrifice, followed by the call to faith and endurance. If you have time, reread Hebrews 12:1-3 slowly. Let it be a rest for your eyes, and let them settle on Jesus.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God."

HEBREWS 12:1-2

REST

Meditation

Hebrews 12:1-2 gathers the week into one picture. After chapters of argument about priests and sacrifices, the author puts you on the track and tells you where to look.

"Let us run with endurance the race that is set before us." The race is set before you. God has not asked you to run someone else's course. He has placed you where you are. And the race requires endurance, because it is long.

"Looking to Jesus." The whole letter has been building to this. After describing his deity, his humanity, his priesthood, his covenant, and his sacrifice, the author says: look at him. When you are tired, look at him. When you are tempted, look at him. When you have failed, look at him.

“The founder and perfecter of our faith.” He started your faith, and he will finish it. You are not trusting in the strength of your own commitment. The one who began a good work in you will bring it to completion.

“For the joy that was set before him endured the cross.” He knew what lay ahead. The cross was real agony, and the joy was real too, because the joy was you. He saw the family he was gaining and he endured.

“And is seated at the right hand.” Again he sits. The race has been run, and the victory has been won. Say the verse aloud a few times today. When fatigue comes this week, let it send you to Jesus.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week brought you to the center of the book of Hebrews. You read about Melchizedek, the priest-king, and saw why the order of Aaron could never be final. You read about the better covenant that Jeremiah promised and the better sacrifice that Christ offered once for all. You saw the shadow and the reality side by side, and you heard the invitation to enter by the new and living way. You paused to consider the local church and what it means to be covenanted with a body of believers. You walked through the great chapter on faith, from Abel to the unnamed martyrs, and saw that all of them were waiting for something better. And you ended with a call to run with endurance, looking to Jesus, who is the founder and perfecter of faith.

The week’s message is simple. Everything the Old Testament pointed toward, Christ has done. You can come with confidence, you can endure with hope, and you can look to him.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

What does “once for all” mean for you personally? Hebrews says Christ’s sacrifice is complete and cannot be repeated or improved. Where do you still try to earn God’s approval, through performance, guilt, or striving? What would it look like to rest in a finished work?

How does Hebrews 12:2 change the way you think about suffering? Jesus endured the cross for the joy set before him. He knew what was on the other side. Think of a current difficulty. How might it look different if you saw it through the lens of the Savior who endured and is now seated in victory? What does it mean for you to look to him?

Who are the people in your life who stir you up to love and good works? Think of one person who encourages your faith, and one person you could encourage. Consider writing a note or sending a message today to say thank you or to offer prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for offering a single sacrifice for sins and sitting down.

Rest in his finished work.

Tell him what you are trying to earn that he has already finished.

DAY 834 · WEEK 120

Hebrews 13:1-25

Love, hospitality, and Jesus, the same yesterday and today

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Hebrews 13:1-25. After twelve chapters of argument and exhortation, the letter ends with a series of practical commands and a closing benediction. Read it as a picture of what the Christian life looks like when it flows from the finished work of Christ. Pay special attention to verse 8 and verses 20-21.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

The author has been building toward a conclusion for twelve chapters. Now, in the closing chapter, the theology becomes concrete. If Christ is greater than angels, Moses, and the priests, if his sacrifice is finished, and if we have a kingdom that cannot be shaken, how should we live? The answer is surprisingly down to earth: love one another, show hospitality, honor marriage, be content with what you have, remember your leaders, and offer praise and good works as sacrifices. The letter ends with one of the most beautiful benedictions in the Bible. The shape of the chapter teaches us that doctrine is meant to produce love.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Let brotherly love continue. Do not neglect to show hospitality to strangers, for thereby some have entertained angels unawares” (13:1-2).
2. Believers are to remember those in prison and those who are mistreated, “since you also are in the body” (13:3).
3. “Let marriage be held in honor among all, and let the marriage bed be undefiled” (13:4).
4. “Keep your life free from love of money, and be content with what you have, for he has said, ‘I will never leave you nor forsake you’” (13:5).
5. “Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever” (13:8).

6. “Let us go to him outside the camp and bear the reproach he endured” (13:13). Christ suffered outside the gate.

7. “Through him then let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God” and do not neglect to do good and share (13:15-16).

8. The closing prayer asks the “God of peace” who brought again from the dead “our Lord Jesus, the great shepherd of the sheep” to equip you with everything good to do his will (13:20-21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The commands of chapter 13 are brief, and each one is rooted in the gospel. Brotherly love is the first. The word is philadelphia, the love of siblings. If Christ has made us family, we are to treat each other as family. Hospitality follows. The example of entertaining angels unawares recalls Abraham in Genesis 18 and Lot in Genesis 19. We never know who is at the door.

The call to remember prisoners is a call to empathy. Many in the original audience had experienced imprisonment, and the author asks them to identify with others who suffer. Marriage is honored. Contentment is the answer to the love of money, and the reason is not “because you have enough” but because “he has said, I will never leave you nor forsake you.” This is a quotation from Deuteronomy 31:6 and Joshua 1:5. The presence of God is the deepest provision. So we can say with confidence, “The Lord is my helper; I will not fear; what can man do to me?”

Verse 8 stands out like a single stone in a wall: “Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever.” The context is a warning against “diverse and strange teachings” (v. 9). Fads come and go, but Christ does not change. He is the same one that Abraham and Moses looked toward, and he is the same one who intercedes for us now, and he will be the same when he returns. His character is as reliable as his promise.

The next section (vv. 10-16) returns to the language of sacrifice. Jesus suffered outside the gate, like the bodies of the sin offerings burned outside the camp. The author calls the readers to join him there. This means bearing reproach, being willing to leave the comfort of what is socially acceptable and the old religious structures. “For here we have no lasting city, but we seek the city that is to come.” We are pilgrims. Yet there are still sacrifices we offer. Not for atonement, since that is finished, but sacrifices of praise, doing good, and sharing. “With such sacrifices God is pleased.”

The leaders of the church are to be remembered and obeyed. They keep watch over souls and will give an account. The author asks for prayer, and then he pronounces the benediction. “Now may the God of peace who brought again from the dead our Lord Jesus,

the great shepherd of the sheep, by the blood of the eternal covenant, equip you with everything good that you may do his will." This single sentence contains the whole letter in miniature: God, peace, resurrection, shepherd, blood, covenant, and equipping. The one who has done the work for us will also work in us. He equips us to do his will, working in us "that which is pleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ." The glory belongs to him forever.

STEP 5

Connection

Hebrews 13:2 recalls Genesis 18-19. The promise of presence quotes Deuteronomy 31:6 and Joshua 1:5, and the confession of verse 6 quotes Psalm 118:6. The sin offering burned outside the camp comes from Leviticus 16:27. The "great shepherd" echoes Isaiah 63:11, Ezekiel 34, Psalm 23, and John 10, and "the blood of the eternal covenant" recalls Zechariah 9:11 and Jeremiah 32:40. The benediction ties the letter to the Old Testament hope of peace and the shepherd-king.

STEP 6

Application

First, choose one practical command from this chapter to act on this week. Welcome a stranger, visit or write to someone who is suffering, honor your marriage or encourage someone in theirs, or practice contentment by giving something away.

Second, memorize verse 5. When you are anxious about money or the future, replace the worry with God's promise: "I will never leave you nor forsake you."

Third, pray for your pastors and church leaders by name. Ask how you could make their work a joy and not a burden.

Fourth, rest in verse 8. Whatever is changing in your life, the Savior is the same. Consider writing the verse where you will see it.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that Jesus is the same yesterday, today, and forever.

Ask him to equip you with everything good to do his will.

Ask him to help you love and show hospitality.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 120

“But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves.”

JAMES 1:22

DAY 835 · WEEK 120

Psalm 22

My God, my God, the psalm Hebrews draws from

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Psalm · 31 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 22 slowly, in two sittings if needed. The first twenty-one verses are a cry of anguish, and the last ten are a shout of praise. The psalm is quoted or alluded to by Hebrews, Matthew, Mark, John, and Paul. As you read, think of Jesus on the cross, because his own words from the cross are the opening line.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 22 is one of the most important psalms in the Bible and one of the most poignant. David wrote it, but he writes with details that go beyond anything that happened to him. As you read, you will find a description of crucifixion centuries before it was invented. Jesus quoted the first line while hanging on the cross, and the Gospel writers echo it in the details they record. The author of Hebrews also draws from this psalm. In Hebrews 2:12, the Son says to the Father, "I will tell of your name to my brothers; in the midst of the congregation I will sing your praise," quoting Psalm 22:22. We close the unit with this psalm because it shows the cost of the salvation Hebrews has described and the triumph that follows.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (v. 1). Jesus quoted this on the cross (Matthew 27:46).
2. David trusts that God is holy and was faithful to the fathers who cried out and were delivered (vv. 3-5).
3. "But I am a worm and not a man, scorned by mankind and despised by the people" (v. 6).

4. Mockers say, “He trusts in the LORD; let him deliver him” (v. 8), the same words the leaders used at the cross (Matthew 27:43).
5. “They have pierced my hands and feet” (v. 16). The bones are out of joint, the tongue sticks to the jaws, and they divide his garments by lot (vv. 14-18).
6. At verse 22, the psalm turns: “I will tell of your name to my brothers; in the midst of the congregation I will praise you.”
7. God “has not despised or abhorred the affliction of the afflicted” (v. 24).
8. The psalm ends with the whole earth turning to the LORD and a people yet unborn hearing “that he has done it” (vv. 27-31).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm begins with the cry of a person who feels abandoned by God. “Why have you forsaken me?” The question is honest, and the psalm does not rush to resolve it. David describes the experience of suffering with God’s apparent silence. He cries day and night, and there is no answer.

Yet even in the dark, David does not let go of God. “Yet you are holy” (v. 3). The word “yet” is the hinge of the first section. His present experience says God has left, but his history says God does not abandon those who trust him. The fathers cried and were delivered. So he continues to cry.

Verses 6-21 are a vivid, almost cinematic description of suffering. David describes himself as a worm, scorned and mocked. People gather like bulls and lions and dogs. His strength is poured out like water, his heart melts like wax, and his tongue sticks to his jaws. They have pierced his hands and feet. They divide his garments. No known event in David’s life matches these details. They fit the crucifixion exactly. Christ on the cross experienced what David described: the mockery, the thirst, the pierced hands, and the soldiers casting lots for his clothing. The psalm is a Spirit-given portrait of the Messiah’s sufferings, and it was written about a thousand years before they happened.

When Jesus cried “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?”, he was not only expressing pain. He was identifying with the entire psalm. He took on himself the experience of being forsaken so that we never will be. The wrath that should have fallen on us fell on him, and in that moment he experienced the separation from the Father that sin deserves. This is the mystery of the atonement, and it is the reason the author of Hebrews can say that Christ’s sacrifice is enough.

Then the psalm turns in verse 22, and the tone changes entirely. The sufferer is rescued. “You have answered me.” And now he promises to declare God’s name to his brothers and praise him in the congregation. This is the resurrection, which is the Father’s answer to the cry. Hebrews 2:12 puts these words in the mouth of the risen Christ, who stands among his people and leads their worship. And the effect reaches to the ends of the earth. “All the ends of the earth shall remember and turn to the LORD.” A people yet unborn, including us, will be told of what he has done. The final word of the psalm is that “he has done it.” This is the Hebrew equivalent of “It is finished.”

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 22 is quoted or echoed throughout the crucifixion narratives: Matthew 27:35-46, Mark 15:24-34, Luke 23:34, and John 19:23-24. Hebrews 2:12 quotes verse 22. The suffering servant of Isaiah 53 parallels this psalm. The final verses link to the Abrahamic promise of blessing for all nations (Genesis 12:3) and to the Great Commission in Matthew 28.

STEP 6

Application

First, let this psalm give you language for your own darkest moments. If you have ever felt abandoned by God, you are not the first. The psalm models honest crying out and a refusal to let go of God’s character.

Second, consider what Jesus did for you. He was forsaken so that you will never be. When you feel alone, remember that your Savior has been there and has made a way for you to be accepted.

Third, take the praise section seriously. David vows to tell others of God’s deliverance. Who could you tell this week about what Christ has done?

Fourth, spend some time in silent gratitude. The one who suffered this was your substitute.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being forsaken in your place.
- Thank God that he did not hide his face.
- Praise him for the great congregation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 120

“But be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves.”

JAMES 1:22

DAY 836 · WEEK 120

Review and Reflection

Unit 23 review, The Better Covenant, Hebrews

Year 2 · Unit 23 · Review

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but one who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin. Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need."
>
> HEBREWS 4:15-16

REST

Meditation

Today there is no new reading. Today is for review and reflection on what you have learned in Unit 23.

Begin by memorizing the verse above if you have not already. Hebrews 4:15-16 is the gospel for the weary believer. It tells you three things about Jesus and one thing about you.

First, Jesus sympathizes. He is not a high priest who looks down at weakness with disdain. He has felt hunger, grief, exhaustion, betrayal, and temptation. When you come to him, you are coming to someone who understands.

Second, Jesus is without sin. He was tempted in every respect, yet he did not fall. This is why his sympathy is not that of someone who gave in. He felt the full force of temptation, more than any of us, because he never gave way. And because he is sinless, his sacrifice is acceptable and his priesthood is effective.

Third, Jesus sits on a throne of grace. The throne is the seat of a king and of a judge. But for those who are in Christ, it is a throne of grace. The one who sits there has already paid for our sins.

And the verse gives you your part: draw near with confidence. Not with arrogance, not with a sense of deserving, but with boldness that rests entirely on him. You will receive mercy for what you have done and find grace to help in time of need. Say it aloud. Carry it with you into every need this week.

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

In Unit 23 you have traveled through the whole book of Hebrews, the sermon that shows how Christ fulfills everything the Old Testament promised. It began with a majestic sentence: God has spoken finally and fully through his Son, the radiance of God's glory and the exact imprint of his nature. You saw that the Son is greater than the angels, who mediated the law, and that he became human to free us from the fear of death. You read the comparison with Moses, the warning from Psalm 95 against hardening our hearts, and the promise of a Sabbath rest that remains for God's people.

You came to the center of the book: Jesus is the great high priest who sympathizes with our weaknesses, who passed through the heavens, and who invites us to draw near to the throne of grace. You read the warning in chapter 6 and the anchor of God's oath. You saw Melchizedek, the priest-king of Genesis 14, as the pattern for a priesthood that never ends. You read the better covenant promised in Jeremiah 31, the better sanctuary, and the better sacrifice. The blood of bulls and goats could not remove sin, but the blood of Christ has cleansed the conscience once for all, and the curtain has been opened by his flesh.

Along the way you paused to consider the Ascension, where Christ was enthroned at God's right hand and began his priestly ministry of intercession, and the doctrine of church membership, where Hebrews 10:24-25 calls us to gather and stir one another up. You studied Psalms 95, 40, 110, and 22, each of which Hebrews draws on to show the voice of the Son. You walked through the hall of faith in chapter 11, where all of God's people lived by promises they only saw from afar, and you heard the call in chapter 12 to run the race, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith. Finally, you read the practical commands of chapter 13 and the benediction that sums up the book: the God of peace, who raised the great shepherd by the blood of the eternal covenant, equips us for his will.

The message of Hebrews can be stated in one sentence: Jesus is better, so hold fast to him.

REFLECT

Review Questions

How does Hebrews demonstrate that Jesus is better than angels, Moses, and the Levitical priesthood?

Look back over chapters 1 to 7. Choose one comparison (Christ and the angels, Moses, or the Levitical priests) and explain in your own words why he is better. How does this help you trust him more fully?

What is the relationship between the Old Covenant and the New Covenant?

Reread Hebrews 8:1-13 and 10:1-18. List two things the old covenant could not do and two things the new covenant does. Which of these matters most to you today?

What does it mean that Christ is our high priest after the order of Melchizedek?

Consider Genesis 14, Psalm 110, and Hebrews 5 to 7. Why does it matter that Jesus is both king and priest, and that his priesthood never ends? Write a few sentences on what this means for your prayers.

What does Hebrews 11 teach us about the nature of faith, and how does it point us to Christ?

Reread Hebrews 11:1-3, 11:39-40, and 12:1-2. In your own words, what is faith, according to this chapter? Name one person from the chapter whose faith you want to follow, and say how each of them points to Jesus.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the book of Hebrews and for the Son it reveals.

Tell him which comparison of Christ meant the most to you.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.